LEADERSHIP AND OPERATIONS

Why Is This Quote Back on Your Desk?

The fastest way to delegate a quote is to find out what the team needs you to decide.



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It's Thursday and a $180,000 quote is waiting for you. Your sales lead and estimator agree on the work. The client wants the price held for 90 days. The supplier's number is good for 30. There's a note in the approval request that says "please confirm."

Two messages down, there's another quote waiting. It's a repeat job at a property you know well. The rep wants to offer the same price break you approved last year. She could send it today if she knew the conditions behind your yes.

Both requests land under "owner approval." One asks you to commit company margin against an uncertain material cost. The other asks you to remember a rule you've never given the team.

Quotes keep coming back to the owner when important information, authority, or unusual risk is concentrated there. Review what the owner actually changes in each quote. Give the team access to repeatable information and authority inside defined limits. Keep commitments with material exposure at the level that can own them.

What does the owner actually do when approving a quote?

Open the version the team sent for approval and the version that went to the customer. Look for what the owner changed and why. A pricing correction, a decision to accept risk, and a sign-off that changed nothing call for different responses.

Amazon Business gives organizations tools to set buying policies and route orders through approval workflows. Its documentation shows how a company can trigger a review based on information such as cost center or location. That's a purchasing example. The useful question for a company approving sales quotes is similar. Can you state what makes an ordinary decision an exception before the request lands on your desk? Amazon Business on setting approval rules

Think of the text you can get from Capital One asking whether you made a particular purchase. The bank describes sending a confirmation for an attempted charge in some circumstances. The cardholder sees the transaction and has a specific question to answer. Compare that with forwarding an entire quote and writing "please confirm." What would you put in the request if the approver had to understand the exception without opening every attachment? Capital One on confirming attempted charges

What should be delegated, and what belongs with leadership?

Delegate an ordinary quote when the team can verify costs, apply the approved scope and terms, and make the commitment inside clear limits. Escalate deviations from those conditions to the person who can evaluate the trade-off. Quote value is one input. The length of the price commitment, cash required upfront and terms can matter more.

Approval request	What the team needs	Where the decision belongs
A repeat site asks for the usual discount.	The reason for the prior discount and the cost it assumed.	Sales, if the conditions still apply and the margin stays inside policy.
The customer wants a 90-day price hold against a 30-day supplier quote.	A supplier extension, revised terms, or a quantified exposure.	The leader authorized to accept that exposure, with input from purchasing.
A design client wants construction-phase services added for a flat fee.	Defined visits, responsibility and a limit on what the fee covers.	The engagement or project leader if the terms fit policy. Escalate novel exposure.

The instruction “you can discount up to 5%” leaves a lot unsaid. Five percent of a standard scope with stable costs may be manageable. Five percent on a job already assuming unconfirmed labor is a different decision. Write a boundary the team can actually check, for example a minimum margin using current quoted costs, a standard validity period, and an agreed payment schedule. Record who can grant an exception and what evidence they need.

What would you put in front of the person approving the 90-day hold?

Give them the amount exposed, the dates, and the choices available. Suppose $72,000 of the $180,000 job is exposed to a supplier price change. An 8% increase on that portion would add $5,760 to cost if the firm absorbed it. If the quote was expected to contribute $36,000 before that change, the same job would contribute $30,240, with the other assumptions held constant. The numbers are illustrative. They show why the owner needs to see the supplier exposure and the effect on the job, not just the face value of the quote.

Purchasing may be able to lock the price against a release. Sales could offer a shorter validity period or discuss different terms. Leadership might accept the exposure for a strong commercial reason. An approval record can show which choices were actually available, what the buyer agreed to, and why the company chose the one it did.

How do you test delegation without losing control?

Pick a repeatable quote type and review a short run of decisions together. Ask the sales lead to record what they would approve, what they would escalate, and what evidence they used. Compare with the owner’s decision and discuss the differences before removing routine approval.

Put the first pass in a **Decision Ownership Record**. For the repeat property, note the standard work, supplier prices used, current margin, reason for the discount, authorized decision maker, and conditions that would trigger review. For the 90-day hold, record what has to be resolved before pricing can be held. A buyer can receive a useful answer while the exposure is reviewed. For example, a quote can explain how long the current price is available and when purchasing expects to know whether it can extend it.

After delegation, track the time quotes spend awaiting approval, what is escalated, and what concessions are discovered after sending. Compare similar work. If approvals fall and the team starts making more off-policy commitments, narrow the authority or improve the input. If the only remaining escalations concern genuine exceptions, review whether the owner needs to handle them personally or whether a commercial leader can take them.

Give the sales lead and owner one case where a price break is justified and one where it would take the work below the company's limit. Ask both to make the call independently. A disagreement is useful. It may show that the margin calculation includes freight for one person and omits it for the other, or that the owner sometimes accepts lower margin when one crew can handle several sites on the same visit. Capture the reason and decide whether it should become a rule. That's how authority starts to survive the owner being out of the office.

Three questions to ask when you open the next approval request.

- What information or judgment does the team need from me?
- Who should have that information or authority the next time this happens?
- What condition would still require someone at my level to decide?

You may still see the 90-day price hold on Thursday afternoon. With a good decision rule, you can read it alongside the supplier's actual terms. The repeat quote is already with the client.

Frequently asked questions

Is a dollar threshold enough?

Use it with the terms that create exposure. A relatively small quote can need review if it adds unusual responsibility or requires expensive work before payment. A larger standard quote may fit established limits.

What if employees still ask for permission after authority has been delegated?

Review the last few requests and ask what made them uncertain. They may lack evidence or expect a different answer when a senior person sees the decision. Work through comparable cases until the boundary is understood.

Can approvals be automated?

A system can route requests using a rule the company can state and check. Preserve the facts behind each decision and give exceptions to an authorized person. Test how the workflow behaves when a required cost or scope field is missing.

The quote scenarios and dollar figures are illustrative. Amazon Business and Capital One are public examples of how specific decisions are routed.